entourage would have been received with brightly coloured flowers of all shades and varieties. Instead, the angry men chose to present him with black clothes and black flowers. This is the ultimate mark of disgrace and disrespect for a man otherwise known as the ‘Mahatma’.

Gandhi’s ignominy in Karachi at the hands of these several young men is an event that stands in stark contrast to how Bose described him immediately after the pact when,

> From the ovation he received everywhere it was quite apparent that his popularity had reached the high watermark. It had surpassed even the record of 1921, when after the departure of Jinnah in 1920 from the Congress Party, he had reorganized the Party’s Constitution around the principle of “Swaraj” or complete political independence from the British, and become its leader’.

He was the ‘Mahatma’ because as Bose explained,

> The spiritual man has always wielded the largest influence in India and he is called a ‘Sant’ or ‘Mahatma’ or ‘Sadhu’. For various reasons, Gandhiji came to be looked upon by the mass of the people as a Mahatma before he became the undisputed political leader of India. At the Nagpur Congress in December 1920, Mr. M.A. Jinnah, who was till then a Nationalist leader, addressed him as ‘Mr. Gandhi’, and he was shouted down by thousands of people who insisted that he should address him as ‘Mahatma Gandhi’.[14]

The fact that several young men could now purport to bestow black clothes and flowers upon him, and so soon after the Gandhi–Irwin Pact (1931), especially just before the Karachi Congress of 1931 was to take place, shows that there had been serious failings on the part of the Mahatma in his dealings with Viscount Irwin in relation to Bhagat Singh.

These failings are nowhere more vividly recognized than in Bose’s book *The Indian Struggle (1920–1942)*, which refers to ‘a lack of diplomacy’ as being also ‘responsible’ for the implementation of the Gandhi–Irwin Pact (1931). This is clear from how ‘on the demand for an inquiry into the police atrocities, the Mahatma had been informed that if he stuck to it till the breaking-point, the Government would yield’ and yet ‘he voluntarily gave up the demand on an appeal from the Viceroy’.[15] This is so difficult to believe so as to be almost incomprehensible. Mahatma Gandhi was an equal